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POEM – THE DARKLING THRUSH

by
Thomas Hardy

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About the Poem

"The Darkling Thrush" is a 32-line lyric poem by Thomas Hardy, written on the eve of the twentieth century (originally titled "By the Century's Deathbed") and first published on 29 December 1900. It is arranged in four eight-line stanzas. The poem is spoken by someone standing alone in a bleak winter landscape at the close of a day – and of a century – whose gloom is suddenly broken by the surprising, joyful song of an old, frail thrush.

Paraphrasing

Stanza 1:

*I leant upon a coppice gate
When Frost was spectre-gray,
And Winter's dregs made desolate
The weakening eye of day.
The tangled bine-stems scored the sky
Like strings of broken lyres,
And all mankind that haunted nigh
Had sought their household fires.*

Paraphrasing:

The speaker leans on a gate at the edge of a small wood on a bitterly cold winter evening. Frost has turned the world a ghostly grey, and the last, weakening light of the winter day makes the scene look desolate. Bare, tangled plant stems cut across the sky like the broken strings of a musical instrument, and everyone who might have been nearby has already gone indoors to sit by their fires, leaving the speaker completely alone outside.

Stanza 2:

*The land's sharp features seemed to be
The Century's corpse outleant,
His crypt the cloudy canopy,
The wind his death-lament.
The ancient pulse of germ and birth
Was shrunken hard and dry,
And every spirit upon earth
Seemed fervourless as I.*

Paraphrasing:

The harsh, jagged shapes of the winter landscape seem to the speaker like the stretched-out corpse of the dying century, with the overcast sky serving as its burial vault and the moaning wind as its funeral song. All the natural energy behind growth and new life feels dried up and lifeless, and every living spirit on earth seems just as drained of feeling and enthusiasm as the speaker himself.

Stanza 3:

*At once a voice arose among
The bleak twigs overhead
In a full-hearted evensong
Of joy illimited;
An aged thrush, frail, gaunt, and small,
In blast-bewuffled plume,
Had chosen thus to fling his soul
Upon the growing gloom.*

Paraphrasing:

Suddenly, from the bare, wind-battered branches above him, a voice bursts into song – a full-throated evening song of unlimited joy. The sound comes from an old, thin, frail thrush, its feathers ruffled by the wind, which has chosen this very moment of deepening gloom to pour out its whole soul in song.

Stanza 4:

*So little cause for carolings
Of such ecstatic sound
Was written on terrestrial things
Afar or nigh around,
That I could think there trembled through
His happy good-night air
Some blessed Hope, whereof he knew
And I was unaware.*

Paraphrasing:

The speaker can find nothing in the bleak world around him, near or far, that would explain such an ecstatic, joyful song. And yet he begins to feel that some kind of blessed hope must be trembling through the thrush's happy, good-night song – a hope the small bird somehow senses, even though the speaker himself cannot perceive or share in it.

Rhyming Scheme

Each of the four eight-line stanzas follows a regular ABAB CDCD rhyme scheme, alternating between lines of iambic tetrameter and iambic trimeter. This tight, traditional hymn-like structure creates a controlled, almost sing-song rhythm that stands in deliberate contrast to the poem's bleak, mournful subject matter – mirroring the tension between despair and the thrush's unexpected song of hope.

Theme

"The Darkling Thrush" explores the tension between despair and hope at a moment of transition. Hardy, known for his pessimism, presents a landscape drained of life and energy as the nineteenth century comes to an end, only to interrupt that bleakness with the thrush's inexplicable, joyful song. The poem does not resolve this tension neatly: the speaker cannot share the bird's hope, only sense that it exists. The result is

a meditation on how hope can persist – unreasoning and unexplained – even in the darkest and most lifeless of circumstances.

Figures of Speech

• Extended Metaphor / Personification

The dying nineteenth century is personified as a corpse (“The Century’s corpse outleant”), with the cloudy sky as its “crypt” and the wind as its “death-lament.”

• Simile

The bare, tangled plant stems against the sky are compared to “strings of broken lyres,” evoking silence and the death of music/harmony.

• Symbolism

The bleak winter landscape symbolises despair and the death of the old century, while the thrush symbolises fragile, persistent hope.

• Contrast / Juxtaposition

The desolate, lifeless setting of the first two stanzas is sharply juxtaposed with the thrush’s ecstatic, joyful song in the third and fourth stanzas.

• Imagery

Strong visual imagery (spectre-gray frost, cloudy canopy) and auditory imagery (the “full-hearted evensong”) work together to build the poem’s mood.

• Alliteration

Phrases such as “frail, gaunt” and “blast-beruffled” use repeated consonant sounds to add texture and emphasis.

Questions & Answers

Q1. Where is the speaker standing, and what is the setting?

He is leaning on a coppice gate at the edge of a small wood on a bitterly cold, frosty winter evening, at the close of both a day and a century.

Q2. What does the speaker compare the wintry landscape to in the second stanza?

He compares it to the outstretched corpse of the dying century, with the cloudy sky as its burial vault (crypt) and the wind as its funeral lament.

Q3. What interrupts the speaker’s bleak mood?

The sudden, full-throated, joyful song of an old, frail thrush bursting from the bare branches above him.

Q4. Why does the thrush’s song surprise the speaker?

Because nothing in the desolate, lifeless surroundings seems to justify such an ecstatic and joyful song.

Q5. What does the speaker sense by the end of the poem?

He senses that some “blessed Hope” trembles through the thrush’s song – a hope the bird seems to know of, even though the speaker himself remains unaware of any such reason for hope.

Q6. What is the significance of the poem’s timing at the turn of the century?

Hardy wrote it as the year 1900 (and the nineteenth century) was ending, using the poem to reflect on the death of the old century and the uncertain, fragile hope for the new one.

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